Company: StrideWear Footwear
Industry: B2B Footwear Manufacturing & Distribution
Project: Customer Retention & Sales Recovery Analysis
Analysis period: January–September 2026
Objective: Identify customer inactivity and declining order patterns to help prioritise sales recovery efforts.

Confidentiality statement:

About this case study: ***StrideWear Footwear is a simulated company identity used to present this portfolio project. The analysis is based on a real-world commercial analysis I conducted in a professional sales environment. Customer identifiers and the presentation have been anonymised to protect confidentiality. The figures reflect the defined customer portfolio analysed and should not be interpreted as verified company-wide totals. This case study demonstrates the analytical approach, problem-solving process, and business recommendations developed through my workplace experience.***

1. Business Problem:

1.1. Business Context

A B2B footwear manufacturing and distribution business had concerns about its sales performance. To better understand customer ordering patterns, I analysed customer activity from January to September 2026 (Q1–Q3) within a defined customer portfolio.

The objective was to establish a clearer picture of customer activity across the portfolio analysed, identify previously active customers who had stopped ordering, and highlight accounts experiencing significant declines in order volume.

These changes represented potential sales recovery opportunities. However, the transactional data alone could not establish why customers had reduced or discontinued their purchases.

The business therefore needed a structured approach to identify the affected accounts and prioritise them for sales follow-up. Through direct engagement, the sales team could investigate the reasons behind the changes, identify issues requiring resolution, and determine appropriate actions to restore customer activity.

1.2. Problem Statement

Without a consolidated view of customer ordering behaviour, it was difficult to identify which customer relationships required immediate attention and prioritise sales recovery efforts effectively.

The analysis was designed to answer three questions:

1. **Which customers had stopped ordering?** Identify previously active accounts with no recent orders for targeted re-engagement.
2. **Which customers were experiencing significant declines?** Highlight accounts that remained active, but whose order volumes had fallen substantially.

3. **Where should the sales team focus its recovery efforts?** Segment customers according to their ordering patterns to support prioritisation, investigation, and targeted follow-up.

The goal was to transform transactional data into a practical customer recovery plan that would help the sales team investigate potential causes of declining activity, address identified issues and pursue opportunities to reactivate sales.

2. Project Objectives

The objective was to analyse customer ordering activity from January to September 2026, identify accounts requiring sales intervention, and develop a targeted customer recovery plan for Q4.

The specific objectives were to:

- Consolidate and clean transactional data from multiple extracts.
- Establish a reliable customer-level view by resolving parent-account and sub-account relationships.
- Analyse customer ordering patterns across Q1, Q2, and Q3.
- Segment customers according to their purchasing behaviour.
- Identify churned customers, accounts experiencing significant declines, stable customers, and new trial accounts.
- Quantify the extent of customer inactivity and declining order activity.
- Prioritise accounts for sales follow-up based on their purchasing patterns.
- Recommend actions to support customer reactivation, issue resolution, and repeat purchasing.

3. My Role and Responsibilities

I conducted a customer ordering analysis to investigate changes in purchasing behaviour and identify opportunities for sales recovery.

My responsibilities included:

- **Data Preparation:** Consolidating and cleaning transactional data from multiple extracts using Excel and Power Query.
- **Customer Data Validation:** Matching customer records and resolving parent-account and sub-account relationships to establish a consolidated customer view.
- **Data Analysis:** Examining quarterly order patterns across Q1, Q2, and Q3 to identify changes in customer activity.
- **Customer Segmentation:** Classifying accounts according to their ordering behaviour to distinguish stable customers, churned accounts, customers experiencing significant declines, and new trial accounts.

- **Insight Development:** Quantifying the scale of customer inactivity and declining order activity to help prioritise sales follow-up.
- **Business Recommendations:** Developing a targeted recovery approach to guide customer re-engagement, investigate potential barriers to purchasing, and support corrective action.

The analysis connected transactional data with practical sales decisions, providing a structured basis for prioritising customer recovery efforts.

4. Data Sources and Preparation

Data Sources

I worked with transactional order data extracted from an internal ordering platform and customer master data. The order records covered **Q1–Q3 2026 (January–September)**.

The order data included records beyond the customer portfolio selected for this analysis. I therefore cleaned the data and identified the relevant customer records before assessing their ordering activity.

Data Preparation Process

4.1. Extracting and combining order data

I extracted order data for Q1, Q2, and Q3 2026. For Q2, I downloaded completed orders and on-hold orders separately because the system did not provide them in one file.

I used **Power Query to append** the separate Q2 files into one dataset. I applied the same overall preparation approach to the Q3 data.

4.2. Cleaning the data

I removed unnecessary columns and simplified the system-generated order IDs to make the records easier to work with.

I also cleaned the customer account codes. Some customers appeared under multiple sub-accounts, so I extracted the parent account code to group related accounts under the same parent customer.

4.3. Matching orders to customer master data

To identify the customer records relevant to my analysis, I used Power Query to merge the order data with the Customer Master Data.

I used an Inner Join, matching records on both the parent account code and customer name. This allowed me to retain order records that matched the customer master records for the defined customer portfolio.

I applied the same matching process to Q3, ensuring that the third quarter was included in the analysis.

4.5. Preparing the final dataset

After cleaning and matching the records, I copied the prepared data into a separate workbook as values. I organised the data into three quarterly datasets covering January to September 2026.

These datasets provided the foundation for comparing customer order activity across Q1, Q2, and Q3.

Outcome

The preparation process gave me a consolidated view of customer ordering activity across the three quarters. With the data cleaned and matched to the customer master, I could move on to analysing quarterly order patterns, identifying inactive and declining accounts, and prioritising potential sales recovery opportunities.

5. Analytical Methodology

After preparing the data, I used Excel formulas and PivotTables to analyse customer ordering patterns across Q1, Q2, and Q3 2026. My aim was to understand how customer activity changed over the nine-month period and identify accounts that required sales follow-up.

5.1 Quarterly Order Analysis

I used PivotTables to summarise order counts for each customer across Q1, Q2, and Q3. This allowed me to compare customer activity across the three quarters and identify changes in ordering patterns.

5.2 Customer Segmentation

I used Excel formulas to classify the 93 customer accounts according to their quarterly ordering activity. The categories included:

- **Stable / Active:** Customers who continued to place orders, with no significant decline that placed them in another category.
- **Still Churned:** Customers who placed orders in Q1 but had no recorded orders in Q2 or Q3.
- **Critical Decline:** Customers whose Q3 order volume had declined by 40% or more compared with Q1.
- **New Trial Accounts:** Customers with no Q1 or Q2 orders but with one or two orders in Q3.
- **Recovered in Q3:** Customers who placed orders in Q1, had no orders in Q2, and resumed ordering in Q3.
- **Inactive / Other:** Customers who had no orders in Q1, placed orders in Q2, and had no orders in Q3.

5.3 Measuring Changes in Order Activity

I compared Q1 and Q3 order counts to measure changes in customer activity. For accounts with previous orders, I calculated the percentage change using the Q1 order count as the baseline.

This helped me quantify the decline in ordering activity among affected customers and identify accounts that needed closer attention.

5.4 Validating the Results

I used Excel filters and the SUBTOTAL function to check customer counts and order totals within the different segments. I also compared the segment totals against the overall figures to ensure that the results reconciled.

5.5 Connecting the Analysis to Business Decisions

I used the results to identify the customer groups that required attention and inform recommendations for sales follow-up. The analysis highlighted **where customer activity had changed**, while further engagement with customers would be needed to establish why those changes occurred

6. Customer Segmentation and Findings

After analysing customer ordering patterns across Q1–Q3 2026, I identified 93 unique parent customer accounts in the portfolio analysed. I grouped these accounts according to their ordering behaviour to understand which customers remained active, which had stopped ordering, and which showed signs of declining or returning activity.

The analysis revealed different patterns across the customer base, helping me identify where sales follow-up and recovery efforts could be prioritised.

6.1 Customer Segmentation Overview

I classified the 93 customer accounts according to their ordering patterns across Q1, Q2, and Q3 2026.

Customer Segment	Number of Accounts
Stable / Active	37
Still Churned	23
Critical Decline	8
New Trial Accounts	13
Recovered in Q3	6
Inactive / Other	6

6.2 Key Findings

Finding 1: A Significant Number of Previously Active Customers Had Stopped Ordering

I identified **23 customers** who had recorded orders in Q1 but had no recorded orders in either Q2 or Q3.

Together, these customers accounted for 45 orders in Q1, representing approximately 8.6% of the total Q1 order volume for the customer portfolio analysed.

Their continued inactivity represented a potential customer retention and sales recovery concern.

Business implication: These accounts warranted follow-up to establish why ordering had stopped and whether the customers could be reactivated.

Finding 2: Some Customers Were Still Ordering but Had Experienced Significant Declines

I identified **8 customers** whose Q3 order volume had declined by at least 40% compared with Q1.

Their combined order count fell from 115 in Q1 to 52 in Q3, a decline of approximately **54.8%**.

Although these customers had not stopped ordering completely, the reduction in activity suggested that their accounts required closer attention.

Business implication: These customers could be prioritised for account reviews and direct engagement to understand the reasons behind the decline.

Finding 3: New Trial Accounts Presented an Opportunity to Build Repeat Purchasing

I identified **13 new trial accounts** that recorded their first orders in Q3, with a combined total of 16 orders.

These accounts had begun purchasing, but their limited order activity meant that repeat purchasing had not yet been established.

Business implication: Follow-up and onboarding could help determine whether these customers had the potential to become regular buyers.

Finding 4: The Stable Customer Base Remained Important to Order Performance

The analysis identified **37 stable or active customers**. Their combined order count increased from 348 in Q1 to 489 in Q3.

This represented an increase of approximately **40.5%** in order count.

Business implication: These customers remained important to order performance and required continued relationship management to support retention and sustain ordering activity.

Finding 5: Overall Order Volume Increased, but the Improvement Was Not Consistent Across All Customers

Total order volume increased from **524 orders in Q1 to 568 orders in Q3**, representing an increase of approximately **8.4%**.

However, this overall growth did not mean that every customer was performing well. Some customers had stopped ordering, while others had experienced substantial declines.

Business implication: Looking at total order volume alone could hide problems at the individual customer level. Customer-level analysis provided a clearer picture of where order activity was increasing and where intervention might be needed.

6.3 Summary of the Findings

The analysis revealed three key priorities:

1. **Recover lost activity:** Investigate previously active customers who had stopped ordering.
2. **Address declining activity:** Engage customers whose order volumes had fallen significantly.
3. **Build on existing activity:** Encourage repeat purchases from new trial accounts while maintaining relationships with stable customers.

The findings provided a basis for prioritising sales follow-up. However, the data did not establish the reasons for customer inactivity or declining orders. Those reasons would need to be investigated through direct customer engagement and internal follow-up.

7. Business Recommendations

Based on my analysis of customer ordering patterns across Q1–Q3 2026, I identified several areas where targeted sales action could help address declining customer activity, recover lost orders, and strengthen customer relationships.

7.1 Prioritise Accounts Requiring Immediate Attention

I recommend prioritising the **31 accounts classified as Still Churned or Critical Decline**.

Together, these accounts recorded 160 orders in Q1 but only 52 orders in Q3: a **67.5% reduction in order volume**.

This makes them an important starting point for the recovery effort.

The objective would not be to assume that all 31 customers could be recovered. Instead, the sales team would investigate the circumstances of each account and prioritise actions based on the findings.

7.2 Resolve Internal Issues Affecting Customer Orders

Where customer follow-up identifies unresolved internal issues, the relevant teams should be involved in resolving them.

For example, billing or payment-related issues may require coordination between Sales and Finance. Other issues may require support from the teams responsible for customer service or order processing.

I recommend tracking each identified issue, assigning responsibility for resolution, and following up to establish whether resolving it leads to renewed customer activity.

This recommendation is particularly relevant where a customer is willing to order but an unresolved internal issue may be preventing the transaction.

7.3 Introduce Ongoing Customer Activity Monitoring

I recommend reviewing customer ordering patterns regularly rather than waiting until the end of a quarter to identify significant changes.

A simple quarterly monitoring process could track:

- Customers who have stopped ordering.
- Customers whose order volumes have declined significantly.
- Customers who have resumed ordering after a period of inactivity.
- New customers who have not progressed beyond their initial purchases.
- Customers whose ordering activity remains stable.

This would help the sales team identify emerging risks earlier and follow up before a temporary decline becomes prolonged inactivity.

8. Proposed Q4 Recovery Plan

Based on my analysis of customer ordering patterns across Q1–Q3 2026, I proposed a targeted recovery plan for Q4. The aim was to re-engage customers who had stopped ordering, address declining order activity, encourage repeat purchases from new trial customers, and maintain relationships with active customers.

Rather than treating the entire customer base the same way, I would prioritise actions according to each segment's ordering behaviour and the findings from customer follow-up.

8.1 Q4 Action Plan

Priority	Customer Segment	Accounts	Proposed Action	Success Measure
High	Still Churned	23	Contact customers to establish why they stopped ordering. Identify barriers to purchasing and agree on appropriate recovery actions.	Number of reactivated accounts and subsequent orders.
High	Critical Decline	8	Arrange targeted account reviews and customer visits where appropriate. Investigate the reasons for declining orders and develop account-specific recovery plans.	Improvement in order frequency and volume.
Growth	New Trial Accounts	13	Follow up after initial purchases, gather feedback, and identify opportunities to encourage repeat orders.	Number of customers making repeat purchases.
Retention	Recovered in Q3	6	Contact these customers to understand their return to	Continued ordering in Q4.

			ordering and identify ways to sustain their renewed activity.	
Review	Inactive / Other	6	Review account histories and investigate whether further engagement could lead to renewed activity.	Accounts assessed and viable recovery opportunities identified.
Maintain	Stable / Active	37	Maintain regular engagement, monitor order patterns, and identify opportunities to strengthen existing customer relationships.	Customer retention and continued ordering activity.

8.2 Implement a Structured Follow-Up Process

To make the recovery plan actionable, I would maintain a follow-up tracker containing:

- Customer account reference.
- Customer segment and priority.
- Date of contact or visit.
- Feedback received and identified issues.
- Agreed next action.
- Person responsible for the next action.
- Follow-up date.
- Subsequent order activity.

This would help the sales team track progress, maintain accountability, and distinguish between accounts that had merely been contacted and those that had actually resumed ordering.

8.3 Monitor Progress Throughout Q4

I would review the recovery effort regularly using the following measures:

KPI	Purpose
Customer Reactivation Rate	Measures the proportion of targeted inactive customers who place an order during Q4.
Order Volume Recovered	Tracks order activity regained from customers targeted for recovery.
Repeat Purchase Rate	Measures how many new trial customers place subsequent orders.
Critical Decline Recovery	Tracks whether customers in the critical-decline segment improve their ordering activity.
Outstanding Issues Resolved	Tracks progress on internal issues identified during customer engagement.

These measures would help determine whether the actions are producing meaningful changes in customer activity.

8.4 Review and Adjust the Plan

I would review the results throughout Q4 and adjust priorities based on customer feedback and actual ordering behaviour.

For example, accounts with clear opportunities for recovery and actionable barriers would receive focused attention. Where customers were unwilling or unable to resume purchasing, I would document the outcome and redirect effort towards more viable opportunities.

This would help ensure that recovery activities remained practical and focused on the accounts most likely to benefit from further engagement.

Expected Direction for Q4

The plan provides a structured approach for turning the analysis into sales activity. Actual recovery targets should be established after initial customer engagement, once the reasons for inactivity and the realistic opportunities for renewed purchasing are better understood.

9. Tools and Skills Demonstrated

This project allowed me to apply data analysis techniques to a practical business problem: understanding changes in customer ordering behaviour and identifying opportunities for sales recovery.

Tools Used

Tool	How I Used It
Microsoft Excel	Used formulas, PivotTables, filters, and SUBTOTAL to analyse quarterly order activity, classify customers, calculate changes in order volume, and validate results.
Power Query	Used to combine separate order extracts, remove unnecessary columns, clean and transform account data, and merge order records with customer master data using an Inner Join.

10. Lessons Learnt

This project strengthened my understanding of how data analysis can support business decisions and improve customer management.

10.1. Data Quality Matters

Cleaning and validating customer records was essential to producing reliable results and avoiding misleading conclusions.

10.2. Overall Performance Can Hide Underlying Problems:

Although total order volume increased by 8.4%, 31 customer accounts were either still churned or experiencing critical declines. This highlighted the importance of analysing performance at the customer level.

10.3. Customer Segmentation Supports Prioritisation:
Grouping customers by their ordering behaviour helped identify accounts requiring different levels of attention and follow-up.

10.4. Insights Must Lead to Action:
The findings informed a proposed Q4 recovery plan, with follow-up measures to track customer reactivation, repeat purchases, and changes in order activity.

Project Summary

This project demonstrates my ability to combine **data preparation, Excel-based analysis, customer segmentation, and business understanding** to investigate a real operational problem and recommend practical actions.

It also demonstrates an important part of business and data analysis: moving beyond reporting what happened to identifying where attention is needed and how the business can investigate and respond.

Key Takeaway

Effective analysis goes beyond identifying patterns. It connects reliable data and business context to practical recommendations that can be implemented and measured.